



**ROCKET SINGH:
SALESMAN OF THE
YEAR 2009**

DIRECTOR SHIMIT AMIN

Harpreet Singh may have been low on marks but not on intelligence. Ranbir showed he could shine in an ensemble cast.

○ **VERDICT** MADE JUST RS 25 CRORE AT BOX OFFICE.

WAKE UP SID 2009

DIRECTOR AYAN MUKERJI

Played Sid, whose aim in life was to spend his father's hard-earned money. Gave him street cred with urban youth.

○ **VERDICT** MADE RS 36 CRORE. GOT CULT STATUS.

RAAJNEETI 2010

DIRECTOR PRAKASH JHA

As Samar Pratap, he was silent but deadly. Pitted against stalwarts, he held firm, showing both range and ability to take risks.

○ **VERDICT** HIT. HELPS HIM ESCAPE GILDED HERO CAGE.

By Kaveree Bamzai

No chinks, no kinks. Well, except for an inch-long cut on his right cheek, sustained when he was rushing to the loo as a child and fell face-first on the pot. A deviated septum which has him breathing from his mouth, making him talk and eat too fast. A childhood which often saw him sit on the steps of his Pali Hill home in Mumbai till 4 in the morning, listening to his parents having raging arguments. And yes, a habit of occasionally talking to dead people—he still remembers a childhood conversation with an imaginary Hitler who sat on his bedroom sofa as he quizzed him about his evil deeds.

But Bollywood can see no wrong in Ranbir Kapoor, whose *Raajneeti* has just had the second biggest opening weekend ever, making Rs 51 crore with a 1,900 print run. In a short career of just six films so far, of which one, *Ajab Prem ki Ghazab Kahani*, was the second biggest grosser of last year, Ranbir is the fresh prince of Bollywood, an actor with Range Rover-loads of charisma. At 27, the fourth generation actor, who grew up in a home of music sittings, costume fittings, story narrations and filmi parties, is busy collecting ace directors and scoring unusual movies in an industry that has started to nudge, if not push, the envelope. Even as he waits for the release of Siddharth Raj Anand's love story *Anjaana Anjaani*, about two people who meet as each is on the verge of suicide, he is starting work with Imtiaz Ali on *Rock Star* where he plays a Jat from Delhi who wants to be a musician, followed by Anurag Basu's *Silence* where he is a hearing and speech impaired man, a second film with Ayan Mukerji, and an as yet untitled film with Mani Ratnam. The range he's shown, from the winsome puppy dog of *Saawariya* to the studied anti-hero of *Raajneeti*, looks all set to be stretched further.

Not surprising then, that there's a spring in the step of producers searching for the next big thing, a gleam of hope for writers looking for a star to peg their difficult-to-sell scripts on and excitement among directors suffering from terminal exhaustion that afflicts everyone waiting for the industry's biggest stars, Aamir Khan and Shah Rukh Khan, to choose the one film a year they will do. In an industry where fates are written off every Friday, he is seen as the boy who will stay.

Collage by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

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Three years and six films old, Ranbir Kapoor has made a career of playing charming chumps but with a startling turn in the ensemble hit *Raajneeti*, his star is on the ascendant.